

Lumexa — Digital Independence Path

Course 18: Professional Presence & Opportunity Building

Lesson 2: Build Your Professional Profile — Instructor Guide

Metadata

Field	Detail
Course	18 — Professional Presence & Opportunity Building
Lesson	2 of course — "Build Your Professional Profile"
Age band	15–18
Format	Live, instructor-led (video classroom), synchronous
Duration	60 minutes
Group size	Up to 12 students (recommended max for 1:1 feedback time)
Prerequisite	Course 18, Lesson 1 (values, goals, and personal brand statement drafted); Course 16 portfolio site live and bio/brand statement finalized
Tools used	LinkedIn (student-eligibility dependent), Canva, Google Docs
Student output	A live/drafted LinkedIn profile section (headline + About + one Experience/Education entry) OR a completed "presence page" section added to their Course 16 portfolio site
Instructor materials	This guide, shared Google Doc template (headline/about worksheet), Canva template link, sample fictional profiles (below)

Before You Teach This Lesson: LinkedIn Eligibility Check (Mandatory Prep)

LinkedIn's Terms of Service set a **minimum age of 16** to create an account. Policy details (minimum age, regional variation, and any account requirements) can change, so **verify current LinkedIn eligibility requirements before every cohort run** by checking LinkedIn's official Help Center / User Agreement — do not rely on prior-run notes. As of this lesson's last verification, the global minimum is 16, with some countries setting a higher local minimum.

This means every cohort will likely have a **split classroom**:

- **Path A — LinkedIn-eligible students** (16+ where LinkedIn permits, and who already have or are ready to create an account, with parent/guardian awareness per Lumexa's under-18 platform policy): build directly inside LinkedIn.
- **Path B — Portfolio-First students** (under LinkedIn's minimum age, in a region with a higher local minimum, or who simply prefer not to create a LinkedIn account yet): build an equivalent "presence page" on their existing Course 16 portfolio site. This is not a consolation prize — frame it explicitly as an equally professional, equally credible option. Many working adults are discovered through personal sites, not LinkedIn.

You must confirm eligibility status per student before class, ideally via the enrollment form or a pre-class Google Form. Do not ask students to self-report age live in front of the class. Have your student roster pre-tagged into Path A / Path B before the session starts.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Write a headline that communicates *specific value*, not just a job title or grade level.
2. Write an About/intro section using a repeatable formula (who you are, what you can do, what you're looking for/curious about).
3. Translate one real, undramatized experience (school project, class, volunteer role, self-taught skill) into a credible profile entry — with zero fabrication.
4. Apply the same writing formulas to either a LinkedIn profile or a portfolio "presence page," recognizing they serve the same function.

Materials Prep (Do Before Class)

- [] Confirm current LinkedIn minimum-age policy via LinkedIn's official Help Center page (do this fresh each term — do not assume last term's answer still holds).
- [] Confirm each student's Path A/B assignment from intake data.
- [] Duplicate the shared Google Doc "Headline + About Formula Worksheet" — one copy per student, or one shared doc with student-named sections.
- [] Have the Canva "Presence Page Header" template link ready for Path B students who want a visual banner/photo card for their portfolio.
- [] Pull up each student's Course 16 bio/brand statement (Path B needs this to check consistency; Path A benefits from it too).
- [] Have the two fictional worked examples (below) ready to screen-share.
- [] If demonstrating live LinkedIn, use a demo/instructor account — never demo inside a real student's account, and never require a student to make a LinkedIn account on the spot during class.

Teaching Sequence (60 minutes)

1. Open & Frame (5 min) — Whole class together

Talking points: - "Today we're not designing anymore — we're writing. Your profile's job is to make a stranger understand, in about 8 seconds, what you're capable of and what you're curious about." - State plainly to the whole class: "Some of you will build this on LinkedIn today, and some of you will build it on your own portfolio site from Course 16. Both are real, professional, and valid — you're building the same thing, just on a different foundation. I'll tell you which group you're in." - Announce path assignments (privately reference your pre-tagged roster; avoid saying *why* a student is in Path B out loud — just state the group).

2. The Two Formulas (10 min) — Whole class together

Teach both formulas once, since both paths use them identically.

Headline formula: [what you do / are learning] + [specific tool, skill, or focus area] + [what you're curious about or working toward]

Example shape: "Aspiring [field] student building [specific type of project] — currently exploring [specific skill/tool]."

About-section formula (4 short paragraphs): 1. **Who you are** — 1–2 sentences, grounded and specific (age/grade optional, context helpful). 2. **What you can actually do** — 2–3 sentences citing *real* things: a project you built, a class you took, a skill you practiced. No invented job titles or years of "experience." 3. **What you're curious about / working toward** — shows direction without overclaiming. 4. **How to reach you or what you're open to** — e.g., "Open to connecting with other student developers" or a link to your portfolio.

Talking point: "Notice the formula never asks you to inflate anything. Specific and true beats impressive and vague, every time."

3. Live Demo — Write One Fictional Profile, Both Ways (12 min) — Whole class together

Screen-share and write live, thinking aloud, using the fictional student below (do not use a real student's identity). Write it once for LinkedIn (Path A shape) and once for a portfolio presence page (Path B shape), so both groups see their version modeled.

Fictional student: Sam Okafor, age 17, has completed Lumexa Courses 1–17, built a weather-tracking app in Course 12 and a personal portfolio site in Course 16, volunteers teaching younger kids basic Scratch coding at a community center.

Path A — LinkedIn headline:

"Aspiring software developer building real projects in Python and JavaScript — currently exploring data visualization and teaching coding basics to younger students."

Path A — LinkedIn About section:

I'm a high school student who's spent the last year learning to build software that actually works, not just tutorials I follow along with.

I've built a weather-tracking web app that pulls live data and displays it with custom charts, and a personal portfolio site to showcase my projects. I'm comfortable with Python and JavaScript fundamentals, and I'm learning how to write cleaner, more readable code as my projects get bigger.

Right now I'm curious about data visualization and how software can make information easier to understand at a glance. I'd like to keep building projects that solve small, real problems.

I also volunteer teaching basic coding (Scratch) to younger kids at my community center, which has taught me a lot about explaining ideas clearly. Open to connecting with other student developers and mentors in software.

Path A — one Experience/Education-style entry (LinkedIn "Experience" section):

Volunteer Coding Instructor — [Community Center Name] Teach introductory Scratch programming concepts to students ages 8–11 in weekly small-group sessions; developed simplified explanations of loops and conditionals for a younger audience.

Talking point: "Notice: 'volunteer,' not 'coding instructor at a company.' True title, true scope, no inflation."

Path B — Portfolio presence-page intro (same student, no LinkedIn):

Screen-share how the *same content* becomes the opening section of a portfolio site — usually titled "About" or "Hi, I'm Sam" — sitting above the project gallery from Course 16. Reuse the identical 4-paragraph About text above, formatted as prose on the portfolio homepage, with a photo or Canva-designed header graphic and a line linking to the weather-tracking app project already on the site.

Key talking point to underline for the whole class: "The paragraph doesn't change based on which platform it lives on. What changes is the container. That's the whole lesson."

4. Guided Build Time — Split by Path (25 min)

Break students into two breakout groups (or two tabs if solo-paced with instructor rotating).

Path A group (LinkedIn): 1. Open LinkedIn (existing account or, if the family has already set one up outside class per Lumexa policy, that account — do not create new accounts live in class). 2. Draft headline using the formula, in the Google Doc worksheet first, then paste into LinkedIn. 3. Draft About section in the worksheet first (draft-then-paste avoids losing work and lets the instructor review before it's public). 4. Add one Experience or Education entry describing a real project, class, or volunteer role — exact title, no invented company or role. 5. Instructor rotates through breakout rooms for 1:1 spot checks (see "How to Review" below).

Path B group (Portfolio-First): 1. Open Course 16 portfolio site (published or draft). 2. Draft the "presence page" About/intro section in the worksheet, using the identical 4-part formula. 3. Decide placement: usually the homepage top section or a dedicated "About" page. 4. Optional: use Canva to design a simple header graphic or intro card

(photo + name + one-line headline) to sit above the About text — this is the visual equivalent of a LinkedIn banner + headline. 5. Add or confirm one "project" or "experience" entry already on the site reads with the same specific, true language (cross-check against Course 16 project write-ups). 6. Instructor rotates through this group as well.

Instructor circulates between both groups throughout — do not leave one group unsupervised for the full 25 minutes.

5. Discussion (5 min) — Whole class together

Discussion questions: - "What's one word you almost used in your About section that sounded impressive but wasn't quite true? What did you replace it with?" - "If a stranger read only your headline, what's the one thing you'd want them to walk away knowing?" - "Path A students: how is a LinkedIn profile different from a resume? Path B students: how is a presence page different from just a project gallery?" - "Why do you think 'specific and true' works better than 'impressive and vague' — even for a recruiter skimming quickly?"

6. Lesson Close (3 min)

- Recap: "Every one of you now has a professional headline and About section written — whether it lives on LinkedIn or on your own site, it does the same job: telling the truth about what you can do, clearly."
- Preview next lesson: extending this presence with a recommendations/references or a "featured work" section.
- Reminder: nothing goes live/public without the instructor's review pass (see below) — worksheet drafts are saved for review before publishing.

Common Misconceptions to Address Directly

1. **"My headline should just be my job title or grade level."** Correction: A title alone ("Student" or "10th Grader") tells a stranger nothing about what you can do. The headline's job is to communicate value and direction, not status.
2. **"My About section should list every skill I have."** Correction: A skill dump reads as generic and is hard to remember. Two or three concrete, demonstrated skills beat a list of twelve. Depth and specificity build more credibility than breadth.
3. **"If I don't have a 'real job,' I don't have anything to put here."** Correction: Class projects, self-taught skills, and volunteer work are real and legitimate. The formula is built specifically so non-employment experience fits naturally and honestly.
4. **"Portfolio-First is the fallback for people who couldn't get LinkedIn."** Correction (say this explicitly in class): Both paths produce a professional presence. Neither is lesser. Some adults deliberately choose a personal site over LinkedIn for their whole career.

Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	What you'll see	Instructor response
Blank-page freeze on About section	Student stares at formula, writes nothing	Have them talk it out loud first — "just tell me what you built" — then transcribe their spoken words into paragraph 2
Over-inflation ("I'm an expert in...")	Language claims mastery not yet demonstrated	Ask "Could you explain that to me right now, live?" — if not, soften language to "learning," "building," "exploring"
Under-selling ("I don't really know much")	Headline/About reads apologetic or empty	Point to a specific artifact (their Course 12 or 16 project) and ask them to describe <i>that thing</i> concretely — specificity replaces false modesty
Path B student feels "less than" Path A	Comments like "I wish I could just use LinkedIn"	Reiterate the presence-page framing from the demo; show that the same paragraph works in both containers
Path A student unsure what counts as an "Experience" entry	Leaves the section blank or invents a title	Confirm real activities (volunteering, tutoring, class project team lead) qualify; help them title it accurately (e.g., "Volunteer," not a fabricated job title)
Inconsistency with Course 16 brand statement	About section contradicts tone/focus set earlier	Pull up their Course 16 bio side-by-side; ask which version is more accurate and adjust the newer one to match
Technical friction inside LinkedIn's editor	Student can't find headline/About fields	Have a quick-reference screenshot ready (captured ahead of class, since LinkedIn's UI changes) rather than live-searching menus mid-lesson

How to Review Student Work (Instructor Checklist)

Before any student publishes to LinkedIn or their live portfolio site, check:

- ☐ Headline is specific (names a real skill/focus), not just a title or grade level.
- ☐ About section follows all 4 parts and contains no invented job titles, employers, years of experience, or credentials.
- ☐ Every claim in the About section maps to something the student can point to (a project, a class, a volunteer role) — ask the student to show you if unsure.
- ☐ Tone is consistent with the Course 16 bio/brand statement (not contradictory in focus area or voice).
- ☐ No personal contact information beyond what Lumexa's under-18 online-safety guidance permits is included (defer to platform safety policy on this — do not approve personal phone numbers, home addresses, or school names if policy restricts them).
- ☐ Path A only: Experience/Education entry uses an accurate real-world title (e.g., "Volunteer," "Student Project Lead") — not a fabricated position.
- ☐ Path B only: presence-page section is clearly placed and visually distinct (via Canva header or formatting) so it reads as an intentional "About" section, not buried text.

Only after this checklist passes should a student hit publish/save-live. Encourage students to keep the Google Doc draft as a backup record of what they wrote.